

Discovery Phase (Example Open-ended Questions)

1. What is getting in the way of you reaching your goals? Are you waiting to play better before you commit to an improvement plan? Instead of thinking about what is possible, can you tell me what you would like to do in your sport? How can you be more specific with your goals?
2. How is that influencing your performance? How often does it happen? How long has this been going on?
Now is the time to go a little deeper into understanding the athlete's frame of mind and use follow-up questions based on the answers you get.
3. What would it take you to give yourself a 10 rating? What is missing, in other words? How can you get beyond that hurdle?
4. How is that belief limiting you? When did this first start? What have you tried to do to get beyond this issue?
5. What drives you to compete in your sport? How do praise or trophies influence your motivation? What do you get out of these external rewards? Do they make you feel better about yourself? Are you a better person for the rewards you get from sports?
6. What does it feel like when you are performing your best? What does your confidence feel like? What do you focus on during execution?
7. What is the major difference in your focus, confidence, composure, etc., when performing well versus not performing well? What are the triggers for you when not playing well? What triggers your performance in those times you do play well?
8. What is your confidence like compared to the most confident athlete you know? What causes you to lose confidence? What or how much does it take for you to lose confidence (i.e., one shot or one round)? How do other people affect your confidence? What situations hurt your confidence? When does your confidence rise?
9. What does it take for you to lose confidence? How quickly? How easily? Refer to the above questions.
10. What are your specific doubts? When do they happen the most? Give me specific examples of how you talk to yourself when doubting.
11. What internal distractions do you have during competition? What triggers the internal distractions? How long does it take you to regain focus? Once you get distracted, are you distracted for the entire game or competition?
12. Are you more likely to become distracted in a big event? When it's time to perform? At the end of the game? Do other people, events, or situations bring on a lack of focus?

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13. What happens when you lose control? What does it take for you to lose control? How often does it happen? How does your performance change when you lose control? Do you lose interest in your game? Do you lose motivation? Are you still trying to play your best but not caring anymore? What happens to your game when you stop trying so hard—does it turn around for the better?
14. Do you become scared or perform more tentatively in competition? Do you worry more about what others think of your performance during competition? Are you afraid of letting others down? Do your expectations get in the way and cause you to play tight or scared?
15. How do other events or people in your life influence your sports performance? What events in life are the most difficult not to take into your sport? When does it affect you the most during your performance? How are you able to overcome these distractions?
16. Are these your own expectations, or have you adopted them from someone else? Follow up on the specific expectations the person talks about to see if they place limits on their performance or are trapped in a comfort zone.
17. At what point do you begin to play defensively? How does your performance or strategy change when you are protecting a lead?
Dig a little to determine the source of the comfort zone (i.e., scores, statistics, wins, etc.).
18. What do you feel is most related to fear of failure—tension, fear, heart rate, self-consciousness, etc.? How does this affect your performance?
19. How does tension affect your performance? When are you most likely to feel tense?
20. How do you plan to address the areas that need work or that have been neglected? Do you have resources to address those areas?